

Episode 9: Once Upon a Time... (7) The Forbidden "X" Paints

It's warm. It's spring. Tokyo is already warm enough that the cherry blossoms seem ready to bloom. The cherry trees in Shakujii Park also seem to be showing a pinkish tint overall.

The problem is what clothes to wear. During the day it's so warm that I actually spend time in studios wearing T-shirts, but temperatures still drop considerably after evening, so if you're not careful you'll catch cold (laughs). But once you've spent the day in a T-shirt, putting on another layer becomes bothersome (bitter laugh). Hmm.

Incidentally, I don't have hay fever, so I'm saved in that regard (laughs).

Well then.

Having joined Toei Doga, I inevitably had to deal with STAC colour paints whether I liked it or not.

Toei Doga divided paints into three groups.

First, about 120 colours for regular TV works. Next, about 70 special colours for theatrical works called **"X (Ekkusu) colours."** And about 70-plus special colours for American "collaborative works" called **"A colours"** (numbered like "A-1").

TV work basic colours had about 5 gradation levels for each colour, organised as a super-average, well-balanced chart that could be used for any work. I once heard that Toei Doga's art department decided this chart saying "Like this..." and STAC made paints according to it, but I'm not sure about that since I never confirmed it (laughs).

"X colours" were gradually added as needed when making theatrical works, since TV basic colours alone weren't sufficient. Incidentally, several colours numbered

"X-51" and above were exceptions - when we took over collaborative works that other companies had been handling, these were colours formulated to match Taiyo Shikisai paints, so these exceptionally had compatibility with Taiyo colours. For example, "X-54" was like Taiyo Shikisai's "200G."

"A colours" were made to match model paints when colour models (colour sample cels) sent from America had colours not available in Toei's paints. For example, "A-7" was *Spider-Man's* bodysuit colour, something like that.

Back then, Toei Doga was constantly making several lines of TV series, but regardless of content direction, all works decided colours based on this basic TV colour chart. It certainly was a well-balanced colour chart, but inevitably everything ended up with similar atmospheres. Since the basics were all vivid, strong colours, even things that should have been intermediate colour schemes were forcibly assigned and arranged. "Bandai colours" was well said - all clear colours like those used for toys. For example, red (B-3), blue (CB-4), yellow (Y-3) were standard.

Ideally, rather than every work using the same colour chart, we'd arrange usage colours according to each work's tendencies - like making this work's chart heavy in earth colours, or preparing lots of blue colour variations for this work.

Anyway, for TV works we could only use colours from this basic chart of about 120 colours. But naturally, we wanted to use "X" and other paints too (laughs). However, using "X" or especially "A" would get you severely scolded by company superiors. Finishing productions would also complain.

Certainly, from work or colour direction perspectives, using "X" at key points would definitely look better, but that meant increasing the number of colours used for painting. Increasing paint colours meant finishing productions had to prepare those colours, costing extra materials. With finishing work unit costs that weren't high, there were harsh realities.

So for example, in character colour decision meetings, spreading colour sample cels and colour chart sheets to decide things, directors and we colour directors wanted to use "X" colours. But we weren't allowed. If we could use this "X colour" here, it would be perfect... such conflicts unfolded.

Toei Doga TV works back then included some categorised as "shadowless works," where even if animation had shadows, finishing didn't need to add shadows by agreement. With cel finishing, adding shadows meant painting required double work - shadow tracing, shadow painting - taking double time. But unit costs were naturally TV rates, burdening finishing productions. So by agreement, "shadowless was OK."

This continued even for *Sailor Moon*.

However, with the flow of time, more works requiring "shadows" even for TV anime increased. Not just adding shadows to raise visual grade, but many characters arranged different colours in shadow colours from normal colour gradations to create atmosphere when deciding character colours. In this context, "X colours" came to be used normally on TV.

Also, the shift of finishing work sites from domestic productions to overseas studios was significant.

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